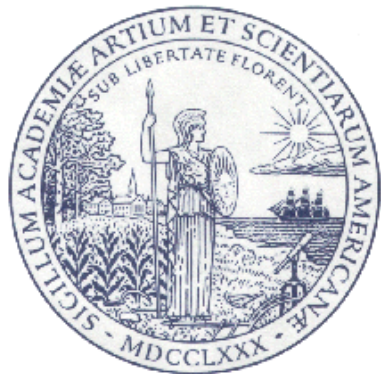




The Construction of Chinese and Non-Chinese Identities

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The Construction of Chinese and Non-Chinese Identities

CONCEPTS OF CHINESE AND NON-CHINESE as the Chinese perceive them are complicated. The single English word *Chinese* not only misses certain meanings but may cause confusion. In Chinese, in both the spoken and the written language, many terms are used to reflect racial, cultural, ethnic, and national attributes (*zhongguoren*, *zhonghua minzu*, *huaren*, *huaqiao*, *tangren*, *hanren*, and so on). These terms have evolved through time; some are recently invented; some originated before the Christian era, but are still popular among Chinese. Such singular terms alone, however, cannot describe the complex situations of Chinese identity. The modern cultural concept of “Chinese,” for example, must be understood in the context of China’s recent political history. In order to create a modern identity to cope with conditions created by China’s confrontation with the Western world, the Chinese were obliged to deal with foreign concepts, including that of nation, state, sovereignty, citizenship, and race; more recently, with cultural and ethnic identity. Chinese officials and intellectuals since the end of the nineteenth century have had difficulty in accepting these Western concepts, especially as they apply to Chinese living abroad, who are often regarded as foreign nationals under international law. The Chinese have also had to deal with the powerful national and racial groups who are not themselves Chinese, but who at one time or other conquered parts or the whole of China, and continue to live today in China’s vast frontier territories. Both of these peripheral situations not only raise interesting intellectual questions about the nature of

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being Chinese and the formation of Chinese identity, but also reveal cultural and political constructs of identity that have had local, national, and international interpretations, leading to negotiations about identity and manipulations of policy by the governments of China and other nations.

To ordinary Chinese, the traditional view of being at the center of existence has always been an important aspect of being Chinese. This anthropocentric view is based on a deep-rooted sense of belonging to a unified civilization that boasts several thousands of years of uninterrupted history. Such a sense of unity and continuity was, until recently, common among all Chinese, even among those who had moved abroad permanently to settle among non-Chinese people. What is the reality of such sentiment today?

Let us first recall the movement of Chinese within the territory of present-day China. Throughout history, the Chinese have moved southward, from the center to what is today the southwest, traditionally perceived to be the location of the kingdoms of the southern “barbarians.” Then, of course, there has been the migration and settlement of the Chinese abroad. In the last two centuries, hundreds of thousands of Chinese have left their homes in southeast coastal China to work and eventually settle in, primarily, Southeast Asia, Oceania, and North and South America. The physical separation of many Chinese from their homeland—the center of their culture—has not precluded the continuity of a Chinese identity. Although it seems natural for Chinese emigrants to maintain their cultural heritage, to emphasize their home-oriented identity, in the last sixty years this sentiment has been reinforced from the “center” through deliberate efforts by the Communist government in China to promote a state version of Chinese identity. As a result, many Chinese in the periphery share common sentiments, though they are physically far removed from China.

Two sentiments identify all who see themselves as Chinese. On the one hand, as *zhongguoren*, which carries the connotation of modern patriotism or nationalism, they feel a connectedness with the fate of China as a nation. Associated with this is a sense of fulfillment, of being the bearers of a cultural heritage handed down from their ancestors, of being essentially separate from non-Chinese. Such primordial sentiments were very common among Chinese in the peripheral areas, especially among those living in the frontier lands,

but also among the overseas Chinese, who were forced to intermingle with non-Chinese.

The Chinese also see themselves as being members of *zhonghua minzu*, a close but inadequate English translation would be “the Chinese race” or “the Chinese people.” Since ancient times, the Chinese have viewed themselves as being at the center, surrounded by culturally inferior barbarians at the peripheries—the Yi in the east, the Di in the west, the Rong in the north, and the Man in the south. *Zhonghua minzu* is a rather modern concept which emerged only at the turn of the twentieth century.¹ The term *minzu* (*min* for people and *zu* for tribe or clan) was adopted from the writings of the Japanese Meiji period, although the two characters used separately were borrowed by the Japanese from classical Chinese writings. By 1895 *minzu* began to reappear in Chinese revolutionary journals, but it was not until 1990 that it became popular among intellectuals.

The term *zhonghua minzu* was first used by intellectuals during the time of the early Republic of China, where it was often associated with nationalistic writings warning the Chinese people of the danger of annihilation under Western invasion. In his article entitled “The Explanation of the Republic of China” (*zhonghua minguo*) the leading intellectual of the time, Zhang Taiyan, proposed an authoritative definition of the Chinese people—*zhongguoren* (people of the middle country).² He writes that the ancestors of *zhongguoren* (the ancestors of the Han) have, since ancient times, been centered (*zhong*) in North China (yet no mention of territorial boundaries), and have called themselves Hua Xia. His article, later cited by leading ethnohistorians, concluded that Hua, Xia, or Han could be used interchangeably to mean China the nation-state, Chinese the race (or tribe), and China the geographic location. According to his word and logic, and that of many Chinese intellectuals who supported him, Hua, Xia, or Han formed a unity—an undifferentiated race originating in North China (which emerged during the legendary Xia dynasty) and was in the process of becoming a modern republic. Zhang Taiyan’s vague and inclusive definition marks the beginning of a modern concept of Chinese national identity. Later efforts were made both in and out of China, through intellectual discourses and government promotions, to construct a Chinese identity based on his nationalistic view.

Both *zhongguoren* and *zhonghua minzu* represent an identity based on concepts of cultural and historical fulfillment rather than the more conventional modern notions of nationality or citizenship. Since most Chinese have believed that the Han people were *the* race of China, one that had absorbed people of all languages, customs, and racial and ethnic origins; the meanings of being Chinese in the sense of ethnicity, culture, citizenship, or residence were almost never addressed. According to the intellectual discourse in the early republic, *zhongguoren* was thought to be the same as *zhonghua minzu*—meaning the five major stocks of the Hua people of the middle land—an idea that is still deeply rooted among many educated Chinese today. By the early twentieth century this concept of a “Chinese people” included four major non-Chinese races, descendants of what were formerly referred to as barbarians: the Man (Manchus), the Meng (Mongolians), the Hui (ethnic groups of Islamic faith in northwestern China), and the Zang (Tibetans). It was also believed that these minority groups, like hundreds of others in the past, had been assimilated into the Chinese culture because of the irresistibly superior Han civilization that had carried on unchanged for thousands of years. For several decades the perception that racial and cultural composition delineated Chineseness dominated the minds of Chinese under nationalist education and Party propaganda.

Recent studies, however, have shown that the existence of a superior Chinese culture is, at best, a myth. The Chinese people and Chinese culture have been constantly amalgamating, restructuring, reinventing, and reinterpreting themselves; the seemingly static Chinese culture has been in a continuous process of assigning important new meanings about being Chinese. However, the Chinese people have not been conscious of using such a cultural construction, and it has significantly affected Chinese individuals in peripheral areas because they are socially and politically situated on the border between the non-Chinese and the category of people considered Chinese. The Chinese, be it *hanren*, *tangren*, or by the 1980s *huaren* (the Han people, the Tang people, or the Hua people), in the peripheral areas have embraced an unspoken but powerful mission: to keep themselves within the acceptable definition of Chineseness and to engage other members within the Chinese community in the preservation of Chinese civilization despite their non-Chinese environment. Although these processes of identity construction have

occurred both in and out of China, they have been seldom documented by Chinese scholars within China.

CONSTRUCTION OF CHINESE IDENTITY OVERSEAS

In the Chinese mind the overseas Chinese or *huaqiao* (the Hua sojourners) are natural members of *zhonghua minzu* as well as *zhongguoren*. Following the traditional thinking of the Chinese people and state, overseas Chinese (regardless of racial mixture) remain Chinese in the fullest sense as long as they are able to claim a Chinese male ancestor, a homeplace in China where this ancestor supposedly emigrated, and observe some manner of cultural practices.

For ordinary people in China, the term *huaqiao* invokes the image of a certain type of Chinese—one who is Chinese but partly alien, wealthy, often associated with America and the Cantonese or, in some cases, associated with Nanyang, the South Seas, and the Hokkienese. Overseas Chinese refer to themselves using a variety of terms in Chinese as well as in other languages, with and without political connotations; these include *huaren* (Hua or Chinese persons), *huayi* (Chinese descendants), and *huaqiao* (Chinese nationals living overseas).

Rising nationalism since the early republic, the threat of Japanese invasion, and discrimination against the overseas Chinese in most host countries, has created the necessary environment for a strong China-oriented identity outside of China. After the Nationalist government was established in Nanjing in 1928 following the northern expedition, China entered a period of “political tutelage” under the authoritarian rule of the Kuomintang (KMT) party. The entire school system of China became a major arena for nationalist indoctrination—especially allegiance to the KMT party and its leaders.³ Nationwide inculcation of Kuomintang ideology in school classes included the teaching of Sun Yat-sen’s Three People’s Principle and speeches of KMT leaders along with lessons on citizenship and patriotism. Outside the schools, the KMT introduced the daily flag salute and national anthem and sponsored weekly gatherings in the name of Dr. Sun Yat-sen for lectures on KMT teachings and military training. This kind of nationalist indoctrination was also brought to overseas Chinese schools via branch organizations of the

Kuomintang party and other overseas Chinese organizations, including the Overseas Chinese Commission of the Nationalist government. Even today the commission regularly sponsors cultural and educational activities in North America and Europe, under the guise of promoting Chinese cultural tradition, in order to induce loyalty to the Nationalist government in Taiwan .

The case of the Chinese living on the remote islands of Papua New Guinea illustrates how Chinese in the center, primarily government officials and intellectuals, were able to forge a Chinese nationalist identity overseas. I conducted research there from 1970 to 1973 on people recognized by themselves and others as “Chinese.”⁴ During our first encounters they often complained that they had suffered for years from discrimination by the European colonists, or in Cantonese, the *loufan* (barbarians). They maintained that they were a people without a country to look after them (*guojia*), although the majority had become Australian citizens during the 1960s.

When I first arrived in Rabaul on the island of New Britain, I was astonished to find the New Guinea KMT headquarters, which was also the center of local politics as the majority of the local Chinese elites were KMT members. Only after a year of study did I realize that the New Guinea Chinese had been recruited and initiated by the KMT during the 1930s, when about one-fifth of the total Chinese population of New Guinea joined the party. In addition to the KMT headquarters in Rabaul, three branch offices were set up in Kokopo (on New Britain Island), Kavieng (on New Ireland Island), and Madang (on the New Guinea mainland). KMT leaders, primarily wealthy Chinese merchants, functioned as political representatives of the Chinese population vis-à-vis the Australian colonial administration, and represented the central power of China in presentations of Chinese culture and education. Until the late 1950s all Chinese in New Guinea were educated in Chinese schools under the wing of the KMT, who recruited teachers from China to infuse New Guinean Chinese youth with a proper understanding of Chinese language, culture, and national identity. These Chinese schools appear to have had a profound influence on the New Guinea Chinese in their formation of a nationalist Chinese identity. A photograph taken in Rabaul in 1953—which I obtained from a family album—depicts a community gathering on a sport ground, with New Guinea Chinese Boy Scouts parading through a Double Tenth celebration arch. The

inscription on the poles of the arch reads: "Donate generously to fill up the national treasury: To counterattack the [Chinese] mainland is the duty of overseas Chinese."

During my stay in New Guinea, I was introduced to KMT members or managers through KMT networks. The organization appeared to still be intact and KMT branches in Port Moresby, Lae, Madang, Kavieng, and Rabaul were in close contact with the KMT headquarters in Taiwan. New Guinea Chinese not only sent representatives to the annual Double Tenth celebration in Taipei, but, according to one regional KMT head, they were sometimes invited to sit in on the National Assembly of the Republic of China to show global support for the government of Taiwan. At the time neither I, then a student of anthropology, nor the Chinese in New Guinea had begun to understand the concept of *huaren* (used to mean ethnic Chinese without political connotations). The New Guinean Chinese considered themselves either *huaqiao* or *zhongguoren*, using expressions like *ngo de wuakiu*; *ngode jonggokyan* (we overseas Chinese; we Chinese nationals). They accepted Chinese patriotism as a matter of duty to one's fellow man, though they were predominantly naturalized Australians. After the Second World War (and until the Republic of China's withdrawal from the United Nations in 1972), the Rabaul Chinese celebrated the Double Tenth holiday each year by performing a lion dance or, as they called it, a dragon dance. Each year they organized a party at the KMT hall which was sponsored by the KMT party of New Guinea and was attended by the Chinese community on the island of New Britain.⁵

During this period the Chinese in New Guinea publicly expressed their association with the KMT and the Nationalist government in Taiwan, but they also quietly gossiped about the rise of the People's Republic of China into world power. By the late 1960s Chinese merchants gradually increased their imports from China—first through Hong Kong and later through direct trade. Because of the conservative anticommunist sentiment of the Australian people—especially the colonial administration in New Guinea—the Chinese never openly expressed their pride about being Chinese and their continuing association with the mainland, although their "ancestral land" had successfully tested the atom bomb, had sent a satellite into orbit, and had reportedly cured the blind and the deaf with traditional Chinese medicine.

The influence of Chinese schools in teaching a China-oriented identity has been even more profound in the larger countries in Southeast Asia that have a substantial ethnic Chinese population. Indonesia is a good example. Before 1957 there were two thousand Chinese schools in Indonesia. These schools were divided between those that were pro-Taipei and those that were pro-Beijing: "In 1958 there was an anti-Kuomintang campaign in Indonesia because of Taipei's involvement in the regional rebellion. The Chinese schools associated with the Kuomintang were closed down. In 1965 there was an abortive coup in which the Communists were involved. Beijing was implicated in this coup, which resulted in the closing of pro-Beijing schools, marking the end of Chinese education in Indonesia."⁶ The five million ethnic Chinese in Indonesia considered themselves divided into two ethnic subgroups: the *peranakans*, predominantly local-born and residing on the outer islands; and *totok*, or in Chinese Fujian dialect *sinke* (new arrivals), which included a large proportion of non-Indonesian born Chinese people concentrated in Java. However, in 1965 the government suppressed the use of Chinese languages, theatrical performances, and religious practices in public. By the 1970s, with the closing down of Chinese schools, the majority of the Chinese children in Indonesia, including the less acculturated *totok*, had lost their ability to speak Chinese.

CONSTRUCTION OF CHINESE AND NON-CHINESE IDENTITIES IN FRONTIER CHINA

It was not until the 1960s, under a Marxist ideology and a Russian model of policy, that the People's Republic established a new concept of being Chinese, which clearly demarcated the Han (ethnic and racially Chinese) and the non-Han (a number of exclusive groups of people representing different cultures, languages, races, and territorial boundaries).

In the 1980s I did research on the minorities in China which raised serious questions about the meaning of being Chinese and non-Chinese inside China. The term Chinese—*zhongguoren*—officially consists of fifty-six *minzu*, or nationalities. The majority of Chinese, who once called themselves *zhongguoren*, now consciously refer to themselves as *hanren* (of the Han nationality), although the Han Chinese are only one of the fifty-six nationalities in China. The Han

constitute almost 94 percent of the entire population of China, but the remaining fifty-five minority nationalities—including the Man, the Meng, and the Hui, well known since the early Republic—reside in over 60 percent of China's territory.

Does being Chinese (or non-Chinese) mean the same thing for the Han, the minority nationalities, and the Chinese overseas? Steven Harrell, in a recent discussion of ethnic group conflict in China, provides an interesting observation.⁷ He proposes that the distinctions between the Han and the minorities in China and those between two groups of Han from different regions of China are “ethnic” differences (in the contemporary social scientist's understanding of the term). But he makes the important point that being Han (ethnic Chinese) does not include a self-perception of being “different” from the mainstream of Chinese culture. The regionally defined groups of Han—Cantonese, Shanghaiese, and Taiwanese, including those living overseas—have obvious ethnic differences in speech, dress, customs, religious beliefs, and so on. Any expert on ethnic studies today will notice that the difference between two Han groups can, in some cases, be more pronounced than that between a Han and a so-called minority nationality group. From their ethnocentric view, however, the Han do not believe that the culture and territorial claims of minority groups are equal to that of the superior Han civilization.

In view of these rather confusing senses of ethnic and cultural identity among the “Chinese” and “non-Chinese” in China, what is the meaning of the resurgence of minority cultures? Government authorities in China, as in other modern nations, have played an active role in changing and promoting ethnic or national identities. To classify a group as non-Chinese in China today is to reinterpret the meaning of minority culture rather than to preserve parts of a past tradition. The present cultural system has been undergoing constant change, and is the reinterpretation or creation of an already changed system, similar to the case of the modern Hawaiian or other “native” American cultures. The new classification of nationalities in China officially emphasizes that each of the minorities has its own language, culture, and history. China's State Council of Nationality Affairs has even published an official ethnography, linguistic study, and ethnohistory for each nationality. Furthermore, one can observe officially sponsored festivals, officially sanctioned religious celebrations, and officially approved songs, dances, and costumes in minor-

ity regions to represent the distinctiveness of the newly named non-Han groups.

Such concerted efforts by the government have been necessary given the fact that under the new ethnic classification many previously anomalous groups, whether by tribal name or by cultural characteristics, have now been subsumed under single ethnic labels. As a result, the revival of minority culture in China has required the creation of new unified, centralized, and pannational sets of cultural symbols and activities. Thus, official efforts to promote Chinese minority groups have also included giving assistance to minorities to create a written language, compile a minority history (glorifying legendary heroes), and restore minority medical practices, and for the composition of minority music, opera, and literature. Field data gathered in the summer of 1985 on one minority group, the Bai in Yunnan Province, illustrates the above processes of cultural construction and interaction between the Han Chinese and the non-Han minorities.

The Bai are the second largest minority of Yunnan, with a population of 1.2 million (the largest minority group, the Yi people, number 3 million). The core of the Bai population resides in northwestern Yunnan, surrounding Er-hai lake, in the Bai Autonomous Prefecture. The capital city includes the ancient town of Dali, which has long been a trade center in the region, and has recently become a popular tourist town to attract foreign visitors. The rest of the Bai people are scattered in east Yunnan, including Kunming—the capital city of the province.

Bai as an ethnic label was unknown to both the Bai themselves and others until 1958 when an official list of nationalities was compiled. Before 1958 the Bai had been known by a number of names, depending on where they resided and whether they were referring to themselves or being referred to by neighboring groups. The most commonly used name was *Minjia* literally meaning “the civilians,” a term developed during the Ming dynasty when the Han military settlers were distinguished from the local residents. In the 1940s one Chinese sociologist observed that the Bai were “not quite a minority, but not quite Chinese either.”⁸ According to ethnographic reports, the Bai who lived in towns and cities were so assimilated to Chinese culture that they were indistinguishable from any other so-called Chinese (or Han, in today’s terminology). They maintained their own

language only in the countryside (yet more than half of their vocabulary was Chinese) and practiced only a few customs that could be considered non-Chinese by anthropologists.⁹

The Bai assimilation to Chinese culture had been going on for centuries, or even millennia, even before their ancestors in the eighth century A.D. established a powerful kingdom—Nanzhao (Nan Chao)—which dominated the Indochinese peninsula and influenced what is today Burma, Thailand, Laos, Cambodia, and Vietnam.¹⁰ During the 1940s when sociologists and ethnologists entered the Bai territory to do field research, the Bai people denied their non-Chinese origin and would feel offended if so regarded. Therefore, the Bai, until very recently, considered themselves to be ethnic Chinese and enjoyed treatment as such. One of the best-known works on Chinese culture, written by anthropologist Francis L. K. Hsu,¹¹ was based on fieldwork among the Bai people during the 1930s. Hsu's field site, in the heart of today's Bai Nationality Autonomous Prefecture, consisted of a township and several surrounding villages. It appeared to be a typical local Chinese center of commerce and agriculture. Local trading firms during World War II expanded their business to international ports as far as Calcutta. The "Chinese" in the Minjia territory (as it was known then) were so typically Chinese that their family and kinship systems as well as their rituals for ancestors, as described in Hsu's book, were thought to be the ideal representation of Chinese society and culture from the late 1940s through the early 1970s.

In 1985 I did field research in a Bai autonomous district, a cluster of five villages situated in a hilly valley, with a total population of two thousand. The majority of the villagers were farmers who grew rice, vegetables, and some fruit, but a small percentage were employed at local factories in the neighboring districts. Local legend had it that the original Bai families migrated here from Dali—the heart of the Bai territory—about 250 years ago. Most villages had once been dominated by one or two surnames, but since the Communist Revolution the local patrilineal clans had officially been dissolved, although local politics continued to revolve around prominent figures of those surnames.

My initial concern was to collect general ethnographic data. As is the convention in my discipline, I expected to find and document a minority culture which was quite distinct from that of the "Chinese";

I did not expect to make a connection between this “minority nationality” and Hsu’s Chinese (the Minjia). I soon noticed that the Bai villagers did not appear to be different in physical features, appearance, behavior, or custom from other ethnic Chinese villagers in the region. I therefore inquired how a Bai, or the Bai people as a whole, could be distinguished from the Han—the ethnic Chinese. No one was able to answer the question save for mentioning language differences. The Bai claim to be bilingual—speaking the Bai language and Chinese Mandarin (Yunnan dialect) with a distinct Bai accent. Linguists have long argued about the likeness of the Bai language to other minority languages in the region, but all have agreed that it is basically a Tibeto-Burman language with a high percentage (60 percent) of its vocabulary adopted from the Chinese. The Bai language has always been easily accepted by other people living in and around the area as a local, rural dialect, since it is common in other parts of China for people to speak mutually unintelligible dialects or languages in places of close geographical proximity.¹² In terms of both language and culture, the Bai themselves believe they are different from others, especially the ethnic Chinese, yet they could not give a convincing explanation for these differences.

Further observations also failed to reveal cultural characteristics that could differentiate the Bai from the ethnic Chinese. Bai family and kinship structure, and their social and political organization at the village level are all similar to those of the ethnic Chinese villages in the region. Although they used to be Buddhists and practiced rituals for Chinese deities on special occasions, these religious activities had stopped in the 1950s. Since the early 1980s, however, some villagers, usually women, have resumed the worship of gods at home and in restored temples. Rituals in memory of ancestors and marriage and funeral ceremonies—all traditional Chinese practices—have become popular for every family. Furthermore, since ancient times the Bai have celebrated folk holidays and festivals celebrated by Chinese elsewhere. Even the Bai architecture shows an adoption of traditional Chinese construction styles. A few wealthier families have even torn down their old houses (of mud bricks) and built modern cement houses, thus making their village houses less distinctly Bai.

All these observations leave an outside observer with the impression that the Bai people have little cultural uniqueness. What is clear, however, are the many cultural elements, though distinctly “Chi-

nese,” which have been associated with the claim of Bai ethnicity in the writings of Chinese ethnologists.

There are great similarities between Hsu’s interpretations of the 1930s and my own findings in 1985. Most of the change in the Bai’s self-perception has occurred because of their officially named identity; where they previously claimed to be ethnic Chinese, they now claim to be a minority—“non-Chinese.” The case of the Bai reveals how the official policy of advancing a minority group’s social status and the minority’s acknowledgement of their new status have had a profound effect on ethnic identity in China.

Our research in China demonstrates how policy can influence the passing on of ethnic identity from Han (Chinese) to non-Han (non-Chinese) for an entire ethnic group. Such a move by a group, or rather the changing of official labels under an authoritative policy, does not require members of the group to change their culture; but it does require a change in their perception and interpretation of their culture so they can justify a new identity. This is the essence of being Chinese or non-Chinese in China today. Such a scenario has applied to many other minority nationalities in China, such as the Miao-Yao groups in southwest China, the Zhuang in Guizhou and Guangxi provinces (the largest minority with over 13 million), the Tujia (2.8 million in Hunan and Sichuan), some of the urban Mongols, the She (in Jejiang and Fujian), almost all the Man (Manchu) in northeastern China and elsewhere in China, and the Hui (the assimilated Muslims residing in urban centers).¹³

BECOMING CHINESE OR NON-CHINESE: PERANAKANIZATION

Throughout the long history of Chinese civilization, Chinese cultural chauvinism notwithstanding, many non-Chinese have been absorbed both culturally and racially into the Han Chinese group, since traditional values have held that being Chinese is culturally and socially superior to being non-Chinese (barbarian). Therefore, we rarely find statements in Chinese literature of Chinese becoming acculturated with non-Chinese. Many in the overseas Chinese communities, however, have long observed that some of their members have “gone native,” and have developed special terms to distinguish them. Many examples can be cited in Southeast Asia, where the

migrant Chinese are numerous and have had a long history of settlement.

Peranakan is a Malay word popular among ethnic Chinese in Indonesia to refer to the native-born Chinese who have gradually lost their mother tongue and cultural characteristics. *Peranakans* may speak the indigenous language of the host country (or a creolized local language), observe some very old Chinese customs and ceremonies as well as acquire indigenous ones, and are regarded by both the unassimilated Chinese migrants (the *totok*) and the indigenous people as belonging to neither group. While the “pure” Chinese may question the legitimacy of the *peranakans*’ claim to being authentic Chinese, the *peranakans* themselves are quite confident about the authenticity of their Chineseness. They are often heard referring to themselves as “we Chinese.” Conspicuous examples of *peranakan* communities are also found in Malaysia and Singapore, where they are known as the “Straits born,” or *baba*.¹⁴

Until recently, it was inconceivable for the Chinese in China to admit that it would be possible for a Chinese within China to gradually give up superior Han Chinese cultural practices, adopt the native way of life, and eventually become a *peranakan* or “native.” However, due to the change of minority policy in favor of minority groups in China and the apparent advantage of having a new minority status, as promoted by the authorities, the acculturated Chinese settlers in some minority regions have even sought official recognition as a distinct ethnic minority. “Peranakanization” (migration out of China, acculturation to an indigenous culture, and subsequent loss of one’s Chinese identity) has occurred repeatedly throughout history. The following is one example of how a Han family became acculturated to the indigenous culture in Yunnan, as described in a prewar ethnographic report.¹⁵

A Chinese man arrives in a minority region and becomes an itinerant trader. After toiling on the road among local villages and market towns, he saves enough money to settle down. He either purchases a piece of land or opens a shop in a market town and marries a native woman. As he prospers and the family grows, he decides to send one of his mixed-blood sons or grandsons to a school in the regional capital, or even the capital city of Yunnan, to acquire a proper Chinese education and eventually to become an official. The idea is that this son, if successful, will carry on the honorable

Chineseness of his family, although the other sons who stay at home may eventually become natives.

To be established in a native-dominated region, a Chinese merchant or landlord must become acculturated to the indigenous culture and use his sociocultural abilities to build friendships with the natives—such a settler is usually a bilingual and bicultural man. The Chinese ethnologist T'ao, who did fieldwork in Yunnan in the 1940s, was not ashamed to admit that a Han settler as such, as opposed to a truly native person, was usually the best informant for visiting ethnologists.¹⁶ It is not unreasonable to assume that some of the Han Chinese settlers T'ao observed might have, in a generation or two, changed their ethnic identity to become members of the minority group they lived with, as many Chinese colonists in Yunnan did during the fifteenth and sixteenth century (the Ming and Qing dynasties).

It is highly possible that some of the Bai people described earlier were descendants of early Han migrants who acculturated with the indigenous people when the Chinese were not as numerous or as powerful as they later became. These “indigenized Chinese,” or Bai, may have later become reacculturated to the Han when further waves of Chinese migration and domination reached the old Bai territory. Turning to the Chinese communities in Southeast Asia, we begin to understand that a comparable process of *peranakanization* has repeatedly occurred among Chinese migrants overseas.

There was a Hokkien (South Fujian dialect) saying among the early Chinese settlers in Malaya: *sa dai sheng ba*—in three generations a Chinese will become a *baba*.¹⁷ If a Chinese man married a Malay woman, and his son also married a Malay, it was unlikely that the grandson would maintain his Chinese language skills and practice of Chinese customs. What Chinese ethnologists observed in Yunnan appears to be typical of early Chinese migration and settlement in Malaya. Ethnographic reports in recent years still document the process of Chinese (considered pure) incorporation of Malay customs, language, and other cultural practices. One interesting example is the way the Malayan Chinese have included Malaya gods, spirits, and non-Chinese figures into the traditional Chinese cosmology and religion. In other words, although the Malayan Chinese continued to live as Chinese on foreign soil, many foreign elements became part of their existence. Anthropologist Newell reports that “. . . the [Chi-

nese] hierarchy of gods was parallel to the government hierarchy in the world. The gods were sometimes regarded as subordinate to officials in this world.”¹⁸ In the 1950s, for example, a tree spirit was making trouble for the workers during a road construction in a Chinese village in Malaya:

In desperation, the Chinese community and the workmen petitioned the [British] District Officer to come and order the tree to be cut down. The District Officer took the axe and gave the tree one stroke. After this, the tree was easily destroyed. In another village the [British] District Officer had to perform a similar task. Underneath the present new village, there used to be a cemetery. Each time the cemetery was cleared, mysterious rumblings and groans were heard so that the workmen became frightened. Finally the District Officer had to sign a notice ordering the spirits or ghosts to remain quiet. From then on no trouble was experienced. [Incidentally, this notice was written in English.]

Chinese flexibility in cultural and religious identity can be seen in the inclusion of native gods in their worship. In north Malaya, Chinese peasants worshiped local tutelary gods. Newell writes: One family has built four shrines to [the local gods] in each corner of their property. In other cases, the earlier Malay inhabitants of the land have worshipped a tree or other object believed to have mystical power, and the Chinese inhabitants have continued to worship the same object.¹⁹

I observed similar patterns of Chinese becoming non-Chinese in Papua New Guinea which parallel the case of the Yunnan described by T’ao as well as that of the Malayan Hokkien mentioned above. The Chinese settled in New Guinea at the turn of the century. By the 1970s, at the eve of the country’s independence from colonial rule, the Chinese community of some three thousand included a minority group of mixed-blood descendants (numbering about seven hundred) whose identity depended on the other’s labeling and interpretation.

The example of a particular family further illustrates the peranakization process. At the turn of the century, a Chinese migrant worker from Taishan of Guangdong Province arrived on New Ireland. He became a coconut plantation manager for a wealthy uncle, married a native woman, and had three sons. His eldest son (who was least noticeably of mixed blood) was sent back to China

for education at the age of eight and was raised there. By the time he reached his forties, life in China had become less acceptable to him. He returned to New Guinea with a Chinese wife and their children where they were received as “Hong Kong Chinese” by the local-born Chinese and the native people of New Guinea. His two younger brothers stayed on the island and both married mixed-blood women. One of the brothers became a local politician and was successful enough to serve one term as prime minister of this newly independent nation. His dark skin and physical features made it difficult for people to distinguish him from the rest of the Melanesians on the islands. Yet, during his recent visit to China with a government delegation representing Papua New Guinea, he spoke Cantonese—a common language of the island Chinese community which he had learned as a child. He was treated, in one sense, as an overseas Chinese returning home. The youngest brother of the three, whose physical appearance was obvious enough to be recognized as a *bun tong* (a Chinese translation of the colonial English term “half-caste”), became the proprietor of the family business established by his father. In three generations, a Chinese migrant’s offspring had become Chinese, New Guinean, and mixed-blood New Guinean-Chinese; each could claim any one of these multiple identities.

In the early 1970s almost one-third of the locally born Chinese in Papua New Guinea (second and third generation) were of mixed blood. Newell observed that, “Judged by its ethnic as well as its cultural characteristics, the Chinese population in Papua New Guinea is not a homogeneous group. Among the Chinese included in my survey only 77 percent are *chin tong* (the Cantonese word for pure Tang people), the rest are *bun tong*.”²⁰ The Chinese on these remote islands were able to construct a Chinese identity using very flexible criteria. Irrespective of the extent of ethnic mixture in a person’s progenitors, if he was descended from a Chinese man, maintained a Chinese surname, and spoke a little Chinese, he was accepted by the Chinese community as a Chinese—*tongjan* (in Cantonese, Tang people). In Kavieng all the Chinese, regardless of ethnic makeup, lived in the Chinese quarter of town. We often heard the Sino-Niuginians, who closely resembled indigenous natives in appearance (in one instance a man’s complexion could be described as charcoal black), refer to themselves as “we Chinese.” For many communities being Chinese depended on one’s wealth and social

status, not one's skin color or degree of knowledge about Chinese culture. A mixed-blood Chinese, if poor, was regarded as a member of the *bun tong* community; however, if he owned a prosperous commercial business, he was accepted as Chinese.²¹ No matter how well the New Guinea Chinese could demonstrate their Chinese language skills or their knowledge of Chinese culture (such as reciting stories from the *Romance of Three Kingdoms* as some did to show off to me—a person of the center), they all ate with a plate, a spoon, and a fork as opposed to the “universal” bowls and chopsticks.

The Indonesian Chinese are another example of Chinese who may have lost all possible ethnic and cultural traits, including language, but are still able to improvise a Chinese identity. Media reports, for example, have revealed that recent government relaxation has allowed the revival of public displays of Chinese identity in the form of temple renovations and celebrations of Chinese folk festivities. A recent article in the *Far Eastern Economic Review* reports that although there has been a revival of Chinese culture by the *totok* in the performance of *po-te-hi* (glove puppet theater, which originated in the southern Fujian province of China, the homeland of the Indonesian Chinese), these Chinese puppet theaters now perform in the Javanese language. “In the early 1960s one could still watch *po-te-hi* performed entirely in Hokkien, but now only the chanted parts are in the dialect, and even then only if the puppeteer masters it. Otherwise, he merely chants nonsensical syllables.”²²

CONCLUSION

For centuries the meaning of being Chinese seemed simple and definite: a sense of belonging to a great civilization and performing properly according to the intellectual elites' norm of conduct. This is what Wang Gungwu referred to as the Chinese “historical identity.” The Chinese as a group traditionally believed that when a larger Chinese population arrived in the frontier land, Sinicization was the only possible course. It was inconceivable that any Chinese could be acculturated by the inferior non-Chinese “barbarians”; however, such acculturation has been a common course of development for Chinese in the frontier land and overseas, although people still insist that an unadulterated Chinese culture is maintained by the Chinese migrants.

Wang, in an article in which he reviews social scientists' concepts of identity and ethnicity and applies them to the Chinese experience in Southeast Asia, points out how complex the Chinese identities are from multiple perspectives of ethnic, national, local, cultural, and class considerations.²³ My discussion has focused on how Chinese conceptualize their own Chineseness in the peripheral situation, demonstrating the complex process whereby they are able to incorporate indigenous language and culture without losing their sense of having a Chinese identity—not even their sense of having an authentic Chinese identity. A comparison of the situation of overseas Chinese with those living in the frontier of China allows us to understand how similar processes of acculturation can have very different political interpretations. Within China official policies alone can label acculturated Chinese as non-Chinese. In the situation overseas, due to the politics and conventional thinking about race and culture, many Chinese who have acculturated to the indigenous population are still labeled as Chinese and subject to suspicion, discrimination, or exclusion in sociopolitical participation. In part, this suspicion is not unreasonable given that the identity for the overseas Chinese has been inseparable from a China-oriented nationalist sentiment for most of the twentieth century.

Since the formation of the early Republic of China, nationalism has preoccupied Chinese intellectual thought both in and out of China. The organizational efforts of the KMT and the Nationalist government, through the activities of the Overseas Chinese Commission, continue to exert their influence in many parts of the world where large numbers of ethnic Chinese reside. This nationalism has been defined in Western terms and has manifested in modern organizational activities such as the KMT party and its affiliated associations, such as the Boy Scouts and summer camps for Chinese cultural learning, national anthems, and other rituals and ceremonies for public demonstration of the ties between the Chinese overseas and their ancestral land of China.

The China-oriented identity of the overseas Chinese will continue as long as the Chinese government—whether nationalist or communist—as well as Chinese intellectuals and community elites overseas continue to recognize its significance. Despite continual cultural change among the peripheral Chinese, the official interpretation of their Chineseness will sustain their meaning of being Chinese.

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ENDNOTES

- ¹See Han Jinchun and Li Yifu, "Hanwen 'minzu' yi ci de chuxian jiqi chuqi shiyong qingkuang" (The emergence of the term 'minzu' in Han (Chinese) language and usage), *Minzu yanjiu* 2 (1984): 36–43; David Y. H. Wu, "Zulei yishi zhi cuangzao yu zaicuangzao" (The construction and reconstruction of ethnic identity), paper presented at the Conference of Ethnic Relation and Regional Development, Academia Sinica, Taipei, 1 September 1989.
- ²Cited in Hu Nai-an, *Zhongguo minzu zhi* (Chinese ethnography), (Taipei: Shangwu, 1964).
- ³Jiequan Li, "Dui dangzhi ji danghua jiaoyu de pipan" (Criticism of party rule and party education), *Mingbao yuekan*, (September 1990): 34–37.
- ⁴David Y. H. Wu, *The Chinese in Papua New Guinea* (Hong Kong: Chinese University Press, 1982).
- ⁵Many Chinese communities, for lack of an alternate Chinese word still call themselves *huaqiao* to this day.
- ⁶Leo Suryadinata, "Government Policy and National Integration in Indonesia," *Southeast Asian Journal of Social Science* 12: (2) (1988): 111–131.
- ⁷Steven Harrell, "Introduction," in Jonathan N. Lipman and Steven Harrell, eds., *Violence in China* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1990), 1–25.
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- ¹³David Y. H. Wu, "Culture Change and Ethnic Identity among Minorities in China," in Chien Chiao and Nicholas Tapp, eds., *Ethnicity and Ethnic Groups in China* (Hong Kong: New Asia College, 1989), 11–22.

¹⁴Chee-Beng Tan, "Peranakan Chinese in Northeast Kelantan with Special Reference to Chinese Religion," *Journal of the Malaysian Branch of the Royal Asiatic Society* 55 (part 1) (1982): 26–52; Chee-Beng Tan, *The Baba of Melaka* (Petaling Jaya, Malaysia: Pelanduk Publications, 1988).

¹⁵T'ao, 28–34.

¹⁶T'ao, 23.

¹⁷Tan, *The Baba of Melaka*.

¹⁸William H. Newell, *Treacherous River: A Study of Rural Chinese in North Malaya* (Kuala Lumpur: University of Malaya Press, 1962).

¹⁹Newell, 99.

²⁰David Y. H. Wu, "Adaptation and Change: the Chinese in Papua and New Guinea," diss., Australian National University, May 1974.

²¹See David Y. H. Wu, "Ethnicity and Adaptation," *Southeast Asian Journal of Social Science* 5 (1–2) (1974): 95.

²²*Far Eastern Economic Review*, 15 October 1987, 52–53.

²³Wang Gungwu, "The Study of Chinese Identities in Southeast Asia," in Jennifer W. Cushman and Wang Gungwu, eds., *Changing Identities of the Southeast Asian Chinese Since World War II* (Hong Kong: Hong Kong University Press, 1988), 1–22.